

■ Ego Depletion

■ What is it?

Feeling too tired or unmotivated to start a new task after the last one.

When you use up mental energy on a difficult task, you often struggle with self-control and motivation for the next one.

For example, after a long day of work, it's harder to hit the gym or resist a late-night snack.

■■ History

The term **Ego Depletion** was introduced in the **1990s by psychologist Roy Baumeister**.

His studies suggested that willpower works like a muscle—after using it, it gets tired, making it harder to stay disciplined.

Although some later research questioned the strength of the effect, the core idea remains useful: **mental energy feels limited, and fatigue reduces self-control.**

■ The Psychology Behind It

- Willpower and self-control draw from the same pool of mental energy.
- After focusing hard on one task, you have less control left for the next.
- This can lead to procrastination, giving in to temptations, or abandoning plans.

In digital products, too much effort can make users quit before finishing.

■■ Why It Matters

Ego depletion can cause:

- Lower user engagement
- More drop-offs (bounce rates)
- Frustrated, tired users
- Impulse actions (e.g., quick exits, random clicks)
- Reduced quality of decisions

■ How to Apply It

- **Keep things simple** → avoid unnecessary pop-ups or distractions.
- **Speed up processes** → fast-loading pages, quick checkouts.
- **Offer incentives** → rewards, badges, or discounts to motivate.
- **Guide attention** → clear CTAs and focused messaging.
- **Encourage breaks** → gentle reminders to pause and recharge.

■ Theory in Action

- **Amazon** reduces steps in its checkout process to minimize mental fatigue.
- **Fast-food drive-throughs** let customers order quickly without leaving their cars, saving time and effort.

■ Final Thought

Mental energy isn't infinite. After long tasks, people feel drained and are more likely to give in to easy or impulsive choices.

Good design respects this by keeping processes short, rewarding, and friction-free—helping users stay on track without exhausting them.